

allow wooden buildings to last for hundreds of years. (Some are designated as World Heritage sites.) And the Kongos are the only people who know how to repair these temples. Generations of the family have built and maintained each building.

The Kongos didn't have some sort of special carpentry gene. According to them, it takes 10 years of apprenticeship to become competent at this type of carpentry.

They also developed a successful leadership succession process. Instead of always handing the reins to the oldest son, Kongo Gumi chose the son (or son-in-law) who showed the most talent for the job.

The Kongos developed organized processes, what we call "soft structures," for succession and training each new generation.

SOFT STRUCTURES

Our family has put in place our own system of soft structures. They are soft because they are not legal entities but merely conventions and protocols that the family sets up for itself. These provide a structure, a system, for managing wealth and harmonizing relationships between family members.

Your family must sing together. These soft structures help get everyone on key. They provide instructions and rules for future generations of family members to follow.

Organizations need rules and structures in order to endure. Even bridge clubs have their rules. So do churches and empires. Families, too. More or less formal structures allow groups of people to get on with their work without having to constantly reinvent the rules.

Think of governments—the U.S. government, for example. It's a governance system of laws and agreements that has been around for over 200 years. It has a history. It has its foundational texts. It has a narrative. It has a governance or leadership structure. It has traditions and rituals, its dos and don'ts, its conventions and protocols. At least in theory, everyone knows how it works and all agree to work within the rules and guidelines it imposes.